

AP 2-D Art & Design: The Complete Exam Guide

The portfolio explained: Sustained Investigation and Selected Works, the written evidence, how 2-D design skills is judged, and 10 practice questions on portfolio readiness.

Hi, I'm **Pigo!** I'll drop tips all through this guide.

**0**

sit-down exams:
it's a portfolio

20 images

15 SI images +
5 Selected Works

60%

of your score is the
Sustained Investigation

83–85%

scored 3 or higher
in recent years

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THE EXAM AT A GLANCE

A portfolio, not an exam

There is no timed test. Your AP score (1–5) comes from a digital portfolio of your own artwork and short written statements, submitted in May. 2-D work includes graphic design, photography, collage, fabric and fashion design, illustration, painting and printmaking.

60%

Section I • Sustained Investigation

40%

Section II • Selected Works

Exam structure

Section	Weight & timing	What you do
I • Sustained Investigation	60% of score 15 digital images	A body of work driven by a question you choose. Show practice, experimentation and revision, with written evidence of your inquiry and how the work developed.
II • Selected Works	40% of score 5 digital images	Five finished works that show 2-D design skills and synthesis of materials, processes and ideas. Each has a short written description of ideas, materials and processes.

PORTFOLIO, NO SIT-DOWN EXAM

You submit your work digitally

There is no timed written exam. You upload images and written evidence to the **AP Digital Portfolio**, and your teacher forwards it to College Board before the May deadline.

SCORED BY EXPERTS

Each section is read independently

Portfolios are scored by at least **four experienced AP Art and Design teachers or college faculty**, trained to apply the same rubric. Each section is scored separately.

How to use this guide

Just starting?

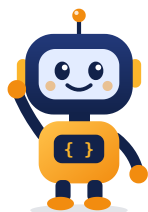
Read pages 2–6, then follow the roadmap on page 8 month by month.

Mid-year?

Check the traps on page 7 and drill the free-response playbook on page 6.

Exam in weeks?

Take the 10 questions on page 9 in 10 minutes, then use the final-four-weeks plan.



Pigo's tip: Start your Sustained Investigation **early**. Fifteen images that show real growth through experimentation and revision take months, not weeks.

02 SECTION I • 60% Sustained Investigation

The heart of the portfolio: 15 images that show an inquiry-driven body of work and how it grew through practice, experimentation and revision.

15

digital images of works and process

60%

of your total AP score

1

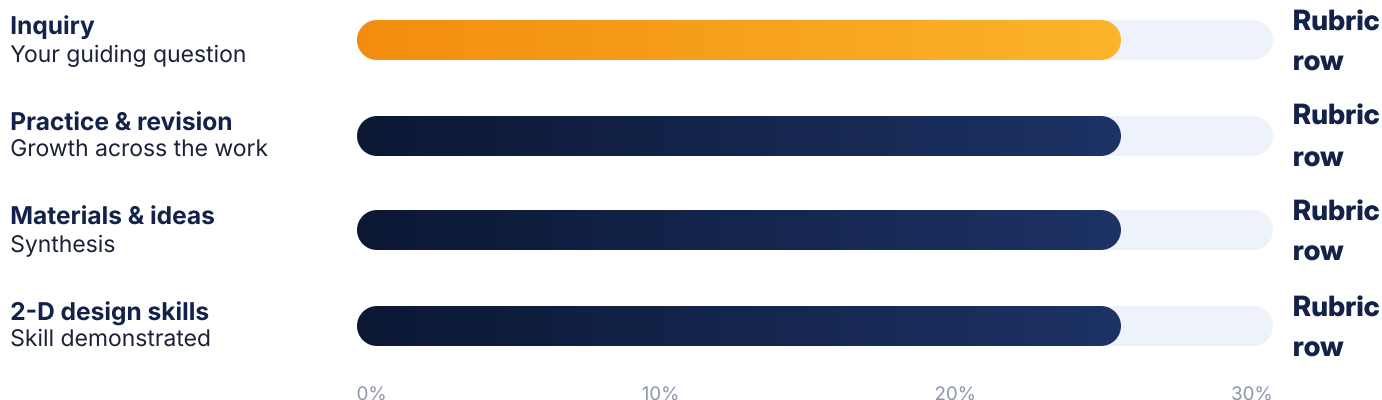
guiding question or inquiry

PER

practice, experimentation, revision

What readers look for

The Sustained Investigation is assessed on these areas. Each matters; none can be skipped.

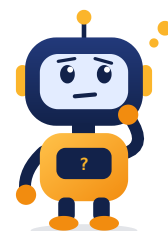


Written evidence: you briefly identify the **inquiry** that guided your investigation and describe how it **developed through practice, experimentation and revision**. For each image you also list materials and processes, and you may label process images.

Strategies for a strong investigation

- Ask an open question you can explore in many ways, not a single theme you illustrate once.
- Show process images: sketches, tests and failed attempts count as evidence of experimentation.
- Let the work change. Readers reward visible growth and new directions.
- Connect images so the 15 read as one investigation, not 15 separate projects.
- Push 2-D design skills across the body of work.
- Write briefly and specifically: name the decisions you made and why.

A "failed" experiment is **evidence** of inquiry. Include it and explain what it taught you.



03 WHAT THE COURSE COVERS

The big ideas & skills

The course is organized around three big ideas, applied through your own artmaking.

IDEA

1

Investigate Materials, Processes & Ideas

Be ready to: reflect on and document your experiences; research artists and approaches; explore materials and processes to inform your work.

IDEA

2

Make Art & Design

Be ready to: develop questions to guide your work; practice, experiment and revise; make decisions about 2-D design skills.

IDEA

3

Present Art & Design

Be ready to: explain how materials, processes and ideas show your growth; select and present your strongest work with clear written statements.

◆ 2-D design skills you must show

Elements

Point, line, shape, color, value, texture, space.

Principles

Unity, variety, balance, emphasis, contrast, rhythm.

Hierarchy

Leading the eye through a composition.

Figure-ground

Relationships between subject and space.

04 SECTION II • 40% Selected Works

Five works that show your strongest 2-D design skills. They can come from your Sustained Investigation, or be completely separate.

Work 1

Work 2

Work 3

Work 4

Work 5

Each work is one digital image

Show

2-D design skills

What readers judge

Readers look for skilled 2-D design skills and a strong synthesis of materials, processes and ideas.

Choose your five strongest finished works, not your favorite subjects.

Write

Written description

For each work

Briefly identify the **ideas**, **materials** and **processes** used, plus citations for any sources or pre-existing works you drew on.

Be specific: "graphite and charcoal on toned paper", not just "drawing".

Photo

Photograph carefully

Image quality matters

Use even light, a neutral background, sharp focus and true color. Crop out everything that isn't the artwork.

Poor photos can hide strong work.

Cite

Original work

Academic integrity

Work must be your own. If you use a photo or another artist's work as a reference, you must transform it significantly and cite it.

Copying a photo without transformation can disqualify a work.

◆ A plan for preparing your submission

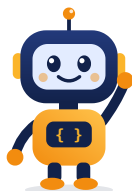
Select works
2 weeks

Photograph
1-2 weeks

Write
1 week

Upload & check
1 week

Work back from the early-May deadline (11:59 PM ET). Check College Board for this year's exact date.



Your teacher must also **forward** your portfolio. Finish early so there's time for both steps.

05

FREE-RESPONSE PLAYBOOK

Anatomy of strong written evidence

Written evidence is short but important: it tells readers how to see your investigation. Here is a strong example, annotated.

PRACTICE TASK • WRITTEN BY ACT SAT GO

Sample Sustained Investigation (AP 2-D Art): A student photographs and redesigns their neighborhood's storefront signs, asking how hand-painted signs shape a community's identity.

Sample written evidence

- ① **Inquiry:** How can redesigning hand-painted shop signs reveal what a neighborhood values?
- ② I photographed 40 signs, then tested digital collage, screen printing and hand lettering to reinterpret them.
- ③ Early collages felt crowded; after critique I used a strict grid and a limited three-color palette to create hierarchy.
- ④ Combining my photographs with hand-lettered type joined documentation and design, showing both the real signs and my response to them.

- ① **Inquiry** stated as an open question.
- ② **Practice:** specific experiments with materials or processes.
- ③ **Revision:** what changed and why.
- ④ **Synthesis:** how materials, processes and ideas came together.

Five habits for a strong portfolio

- 1** Photograph process and finished work as you go.
- 2** Keep a sketchbook or log of every decision.
- 3** Write evidence in plain, specific language.
- 4** Cite any reference images or sources.
- 5** Get honest feedback on your weakest five images.

06 LEARN FROM OTHERS

10 traps that cost points

Meet **Glitch**. He lives in these ten mistakes. Squash each one before May.

Fifteen pretty pictures = **investigation!** (No.)



01 Theme instead of inquiry

"Nature" is a theme. "How can texture show the passage of time?" is an inquiry that drives work.

02 No visible growth

Fifteen similar finished works don't show practice, experimentation or revision.

03 Hiding process

Sketches and tests are evidence. Include and label them.

04 Vague writing

"I explored my feelings" says little. Name materials, decisions and changes.

05 Copying photos

Work based on others' images must be significantly transformed and cited.

06 Poor photography

Blurry, glare-filled or badly cropped images hide your skill.

07 Disconnected works

Your investigation should read as one connected body of work.

08 Weak Selected Works

Choose the five works that best show skill and synthesis, not just your favorites.

09 Ignoring composition

Readers judge composition and design decisions, not just technique.

10 Missing the deadline

Upload, write and submit early; your teacher must also forward the portfolio.

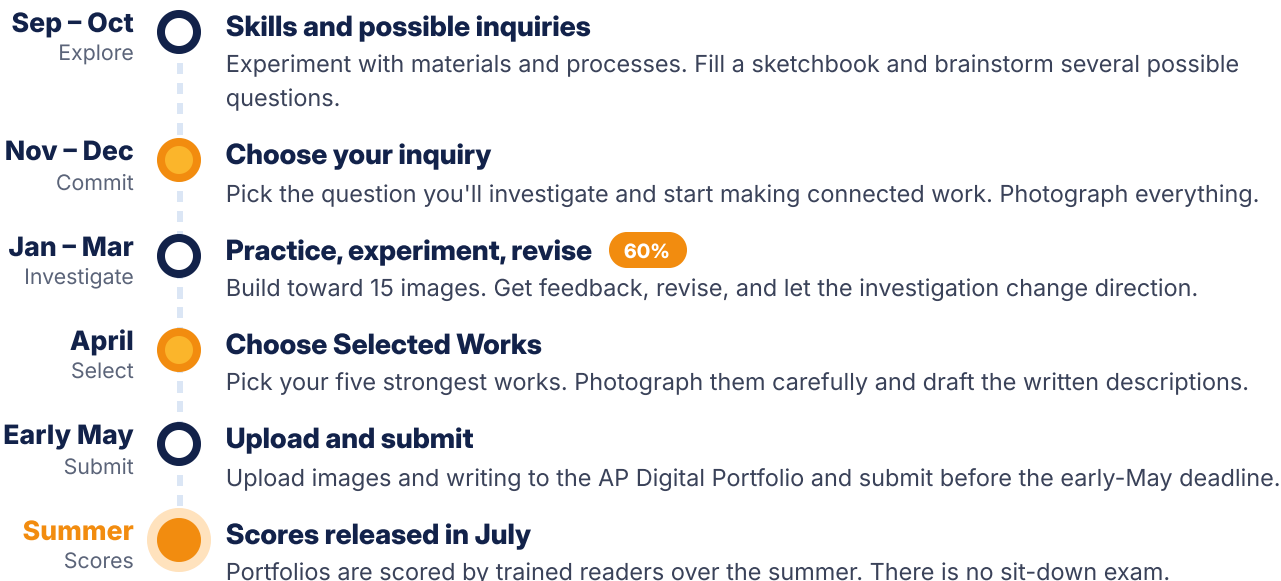
Quick self-check: can you state your inquiry as a question, and point to three images that show it changing through experimentation or revision?



PLAN YOUR YEAR

Your study roadmap to May

A portfolio grows over the whole year. Use this plan to keep your Sustained Investigation moving.



◆ The final four weeks

Week	Focus	Target
4 weeks before deadline	All 15 SI images made	Show clear growth
3 weeks before	Photograph all works	Sharp, even light, true color
2 weeks before	Write evidence and descriptions	Specific and concise
Final week	Upload, review, submit	Submitted before the deadline

08 TEST YOURSELF 10 portfolio-readiness questions

Original questions written by ACT SAT GO to check your understanding of portfolio requirements and art-and-design thinking (there is no multiple-choice exam). Give yourself **10 minutes**, then check page 10.

1 PORTFOLIO STRUCTURE

How many digital images are required for the Sustained Investigation?

- A 5
- B 10
- C 15
- D 20

2 PORTFOLIO STRUCTURE

What share of the AP score comes from the Sustained Investigation?

- A 40%
- B 50%
- C 60%
- D 75%

3 INQUIRY

Which is the strongest guiding inquiry?

- A Photos of my city
- B Graphic design
- C My summer vacation
- D How can color temperature change the mood of the same street at different times?

4 DESIGN PRINCIPLES

Making one element stand out so the viewer looks there first is called:

- A Emphasis
- B Rhythm
- C Unity
- D Repetition

5 DESIGN PRINCIPLES

An asymmetrical composition that still feels stable shows:

- A radial balance
- B informal (asymmetrical) balance
- C pattern
- D unity through repetition only

6 ORIGINALITY

You use a stock photo in a collage. To meet requirements you must:

- A use it unchanged
- B avoid mentioning it
- C only use free images
- D transform it significantly and cite the source

7 EVIDENCE

Which image best shows **revision**?

- A Two versions of a poster, the second with clearer hierarchy after feedback
- B A photo of your sketchbook cover
- C A list of materials
- D A copy of a famous logo

8 MEDIA

Which of the following can be submitted in the 2-D portfolio?

- A Only painting
- B Graphic design, photography, collage, illustration, painting and printmaking
- C Only digital work
- D Only sculpture

9 WRITING

Which process description is most useful to readers?

- A "Computer"
- B "Art"
- C "I made it"
- D "Scanned linocut prints, layered and recolored in Photoshop, printed on cotton paper"

10 SUBMISSION

The portfolio is submitted:

- A as digital images through the AP Digital Portfolio before the early-May deadline
- B as printed originals by mail
- C at a timed exam
- D in June

09

CHECK YOUR WORK

Answer key & explanations

Read every explanation, even for questions you got right. Each one points to a pattern that keeps coming back on the exam.

#	Answer	Why
1	C • 15	The Sustained Investigation requires 15 digital images.
2	C • 60%	The Sustained Investigation is 60%; Selected Works is 40%.
3	D	It is an open, exploratory question about a specific design choice (color temperature and mood).
4	A • Emphasis	Emphasis creates a focal point that draws the eye first.
5	B	Asymmetrical (informal) balance distributes visual weight unevenly but still feels stable.
6	D	Work using others' images must be significantly transformed and cited.
7	A	A before-and-after showing a change in response to feedback is clear evidence of revision.
8	B	The 2-D portfolio accepts a wide range of two-dimensional media.
9	D	Specific processes and materials help readers understand your decisions.
10	A	Portfolios are uploaded digitally to the AP Digital Portfolio before the early-May deadline.

9–10

Ready. Focus on making and photographing your strongest work.

6–8

Nearly there. Re-read the requirements on the Sustained Investigation page.

0–5

Review the portfolio structure with your teacher before going further.

10 KNOW THE TARGET How students score

In recent years, about 83–85% of students earned a 3 or higher on AP 2-D Art and Design, and about 12% earned a 5. Portfolio scores reward a clear inquiry and visible growth over the year.

83–85%

of students earned a 3 or higher in recent years

12%

earned the top score of 5 in recent years

3+

is the score many colleges accept for credit or placement

What each AP score means

5

Extremely well qualified

4

Very well qualified

3

Qualified

2

Possibly qualified

1

No recommendation

Ranges reflect recent College Board score distributions and shift a little each year. Credit and placement policies vary by college, so check each college's AP policy.

Exam-day checklist

- ☐ All **15 Sustained Investigation** images uploaded
- ☐ All reference sources **cited**
- ☐ **5 Selected Works** images uploaded
- ☐ Photos are **sharp, well lit and cropped**
- ☐ Written evidence for the **inquiry** and **practice, experimentation and revision**
- ☐ Portfolio **submitted** in the AP Digital Portfolio before the early-May deadline
- ☐ Ideas, materials and processes listed for **every work**
- ☐ Teacher has **forwarded** your portfolio to College Board

For your portfolio: pursue a real question, show growth through practice, experimentation and revision, write specific evidence, cite your sources, and present every image clearly.



ACT SAT GO • 1-ON-1 AP TUTORING

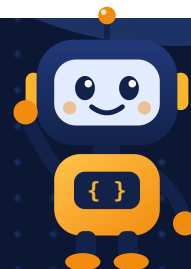
Aiming for a 5? Get a personal AP 2-D Art plan.

Book a free consultation. We'll help you plan your investigation timeline, strengthen your written evidence skills, and prepare your submission. Your artwork stays entirely your own.

Book a free diagnostic lesson →



Scan to book
www.actsatgo.com/consultation



Portfolio planning

One-on-one sessions to plan your timeline, inquiry and photography workflow.

Writing skills

Coaching on clear, specific written evidence. We teach skills; your art and words stay 100% your own.

Critique practice

Practice critiquing and revising using sample works, so you can judge your own work objectively.

◆ Contact us

Web www.actsatgo.com

Email info@actsatgo.com

Phone [+1 \(945\) 391-6179](tel:+19453916179)

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